

Asia before Colonial Times

Francis Bond

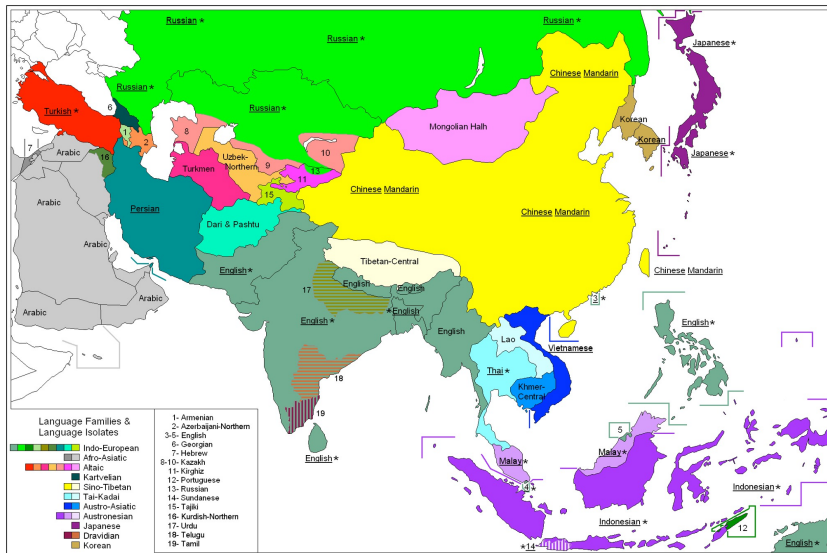
based on slides by František Kratochvíl

2026

Overview

- 1 Language Families of Asia
- 2 Geography and Climate
- 3 Crops and Domestication
- 4 Lexical Borrowing

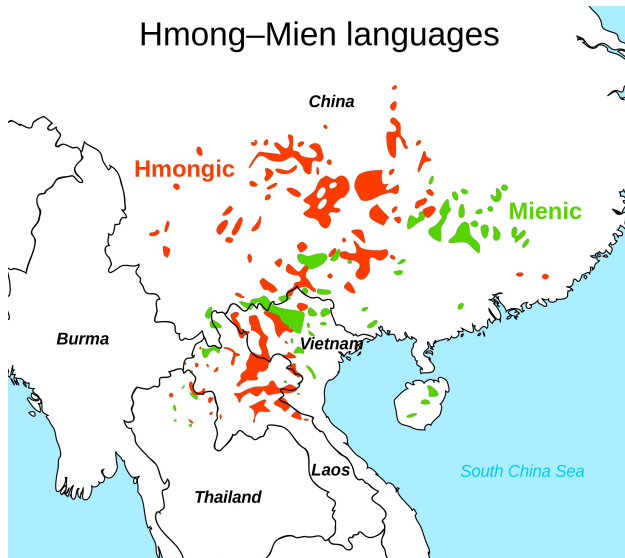
Major languages of Asia



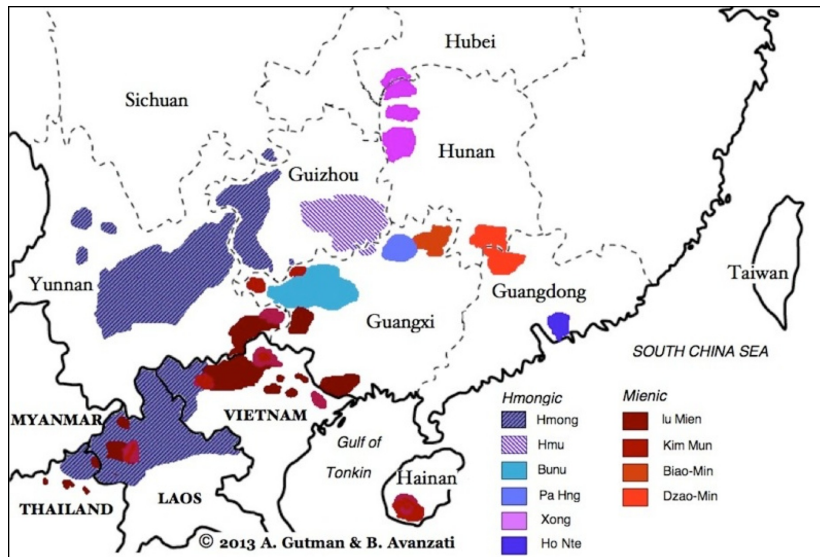
Austro-Asiatic family



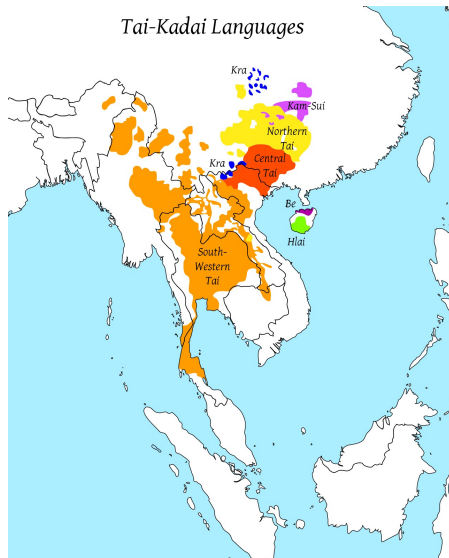
Hmong-Mien family



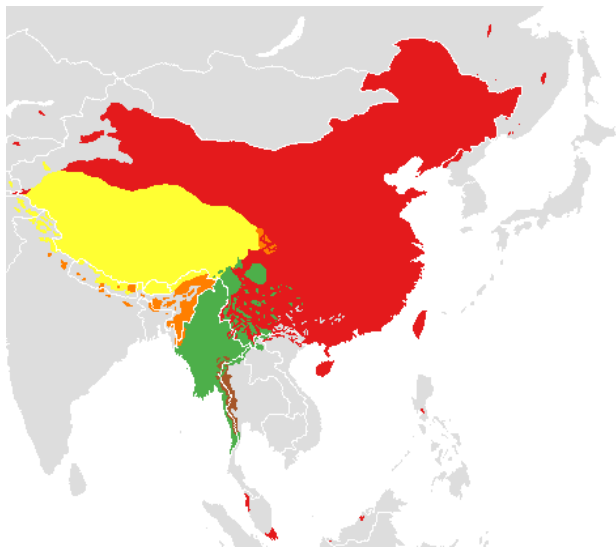
Hmong-Mien family



Tai-Kadai family (probably a branch of Austronesian)

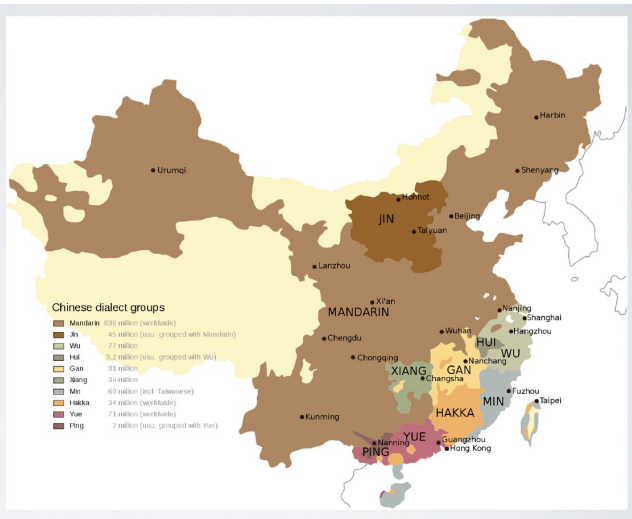
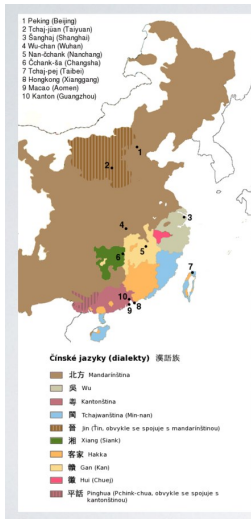


Sino-Tibetan family

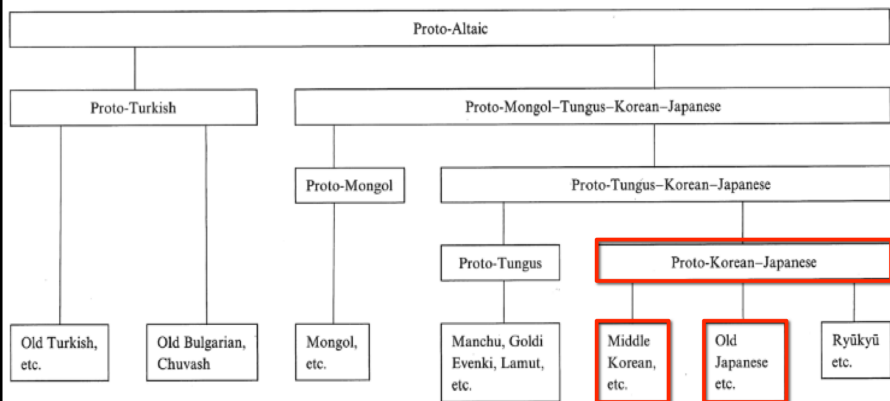


■ Sinitic ■ Tibetic ■ Lolo-Burmese ■ Karenic ■ other (Kuki, Chin, Naga, ...)

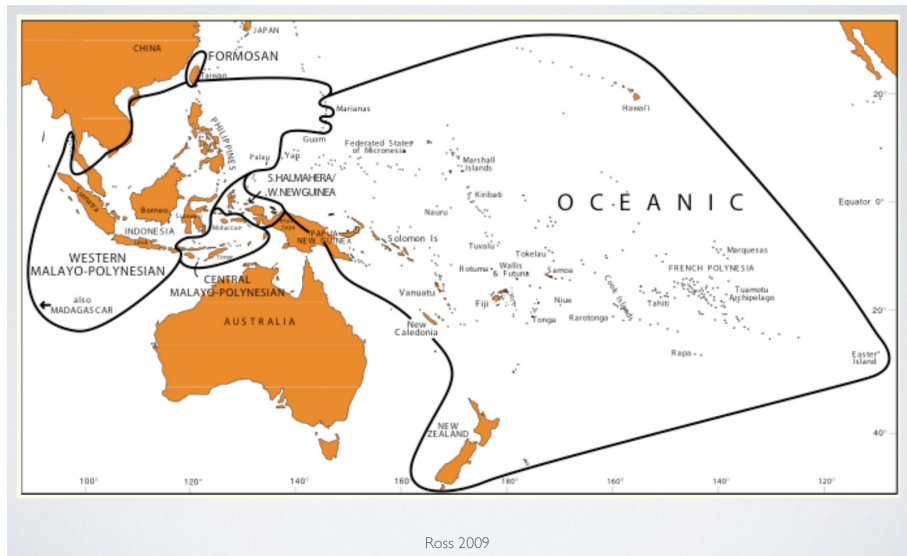
Sinitic branch



Altaic hypothesis



The integrity of the Austronesian language family



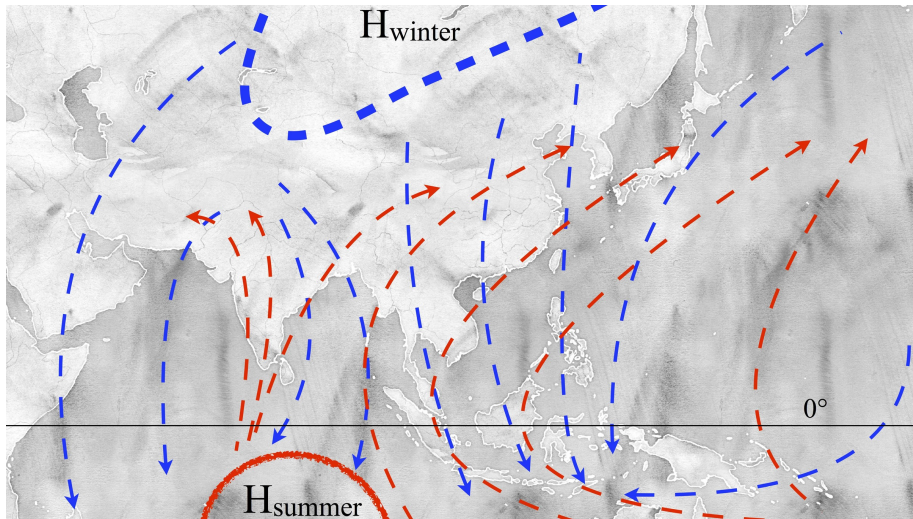
Relief of East and Southeast Asia



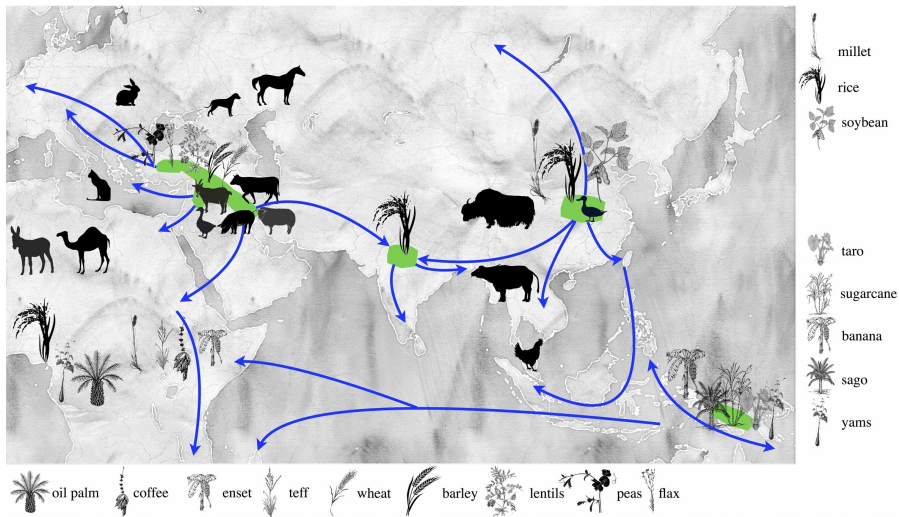
Relief of mainland Southeast Asia



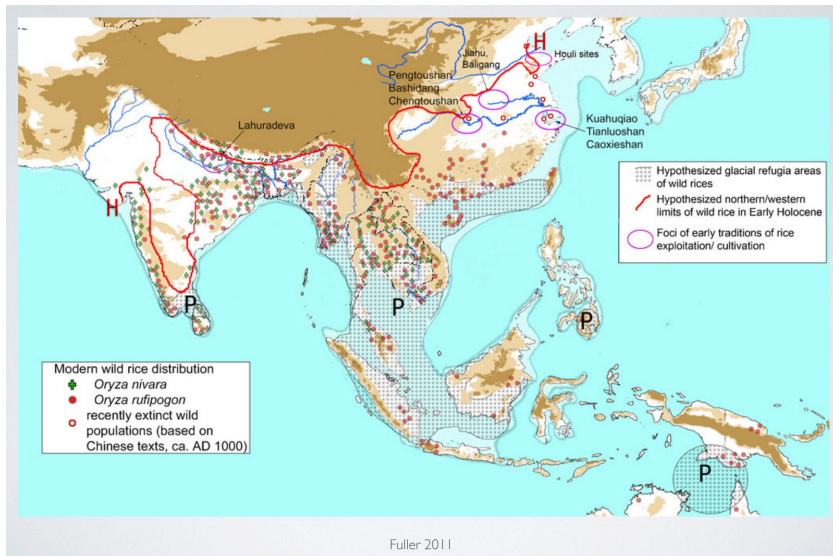
Monsoon patterns



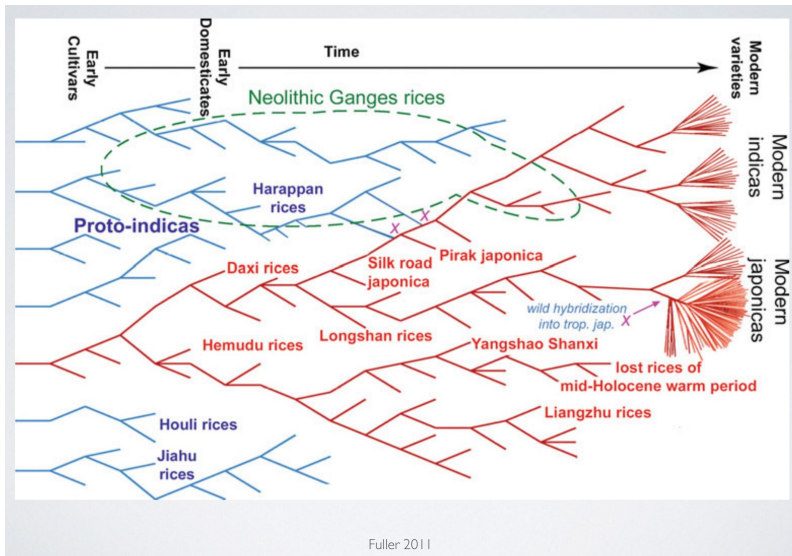
Cultural crops



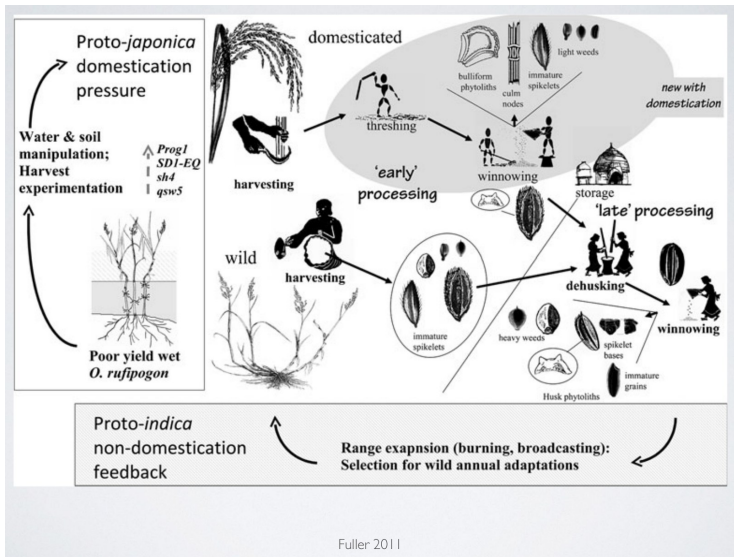
Last glacial period sea levels and natural refugia of wild rice



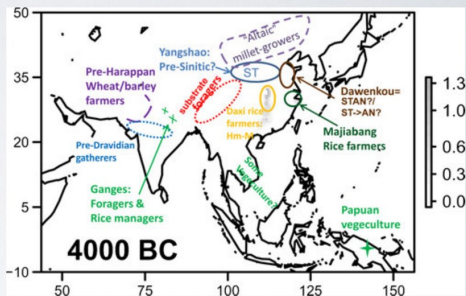
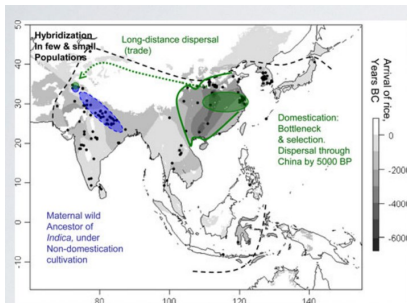
Genetic diversity of rice



Domestication pressures on rice

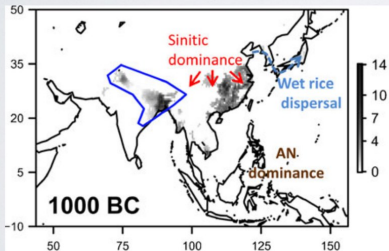
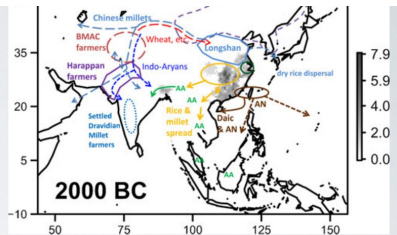
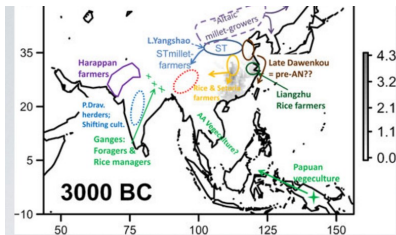


Spreading of rice hybrids

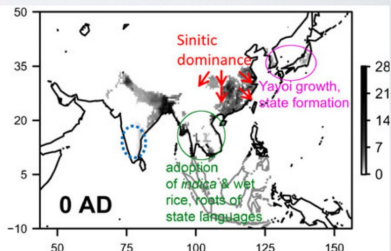


Fuller 2011

Spreading of rice hybrids

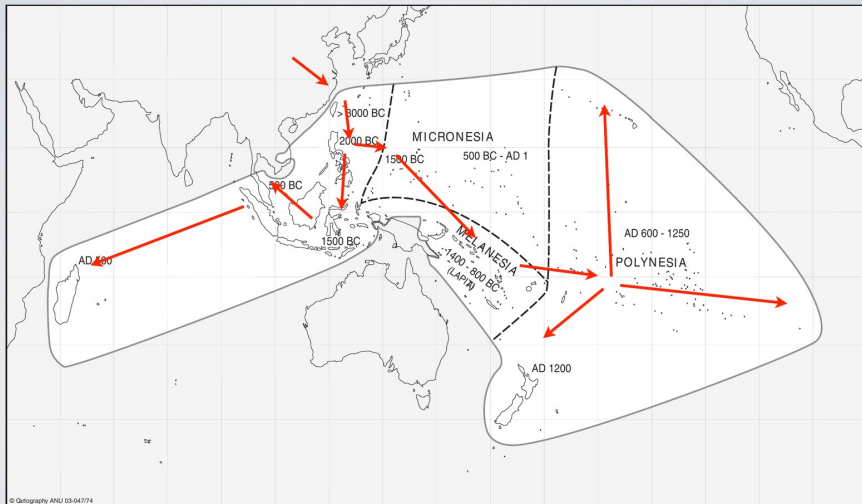


Major population growth
Pushed Indo-Aryan to dominance;
State-formation; Dispersal to Ceylon



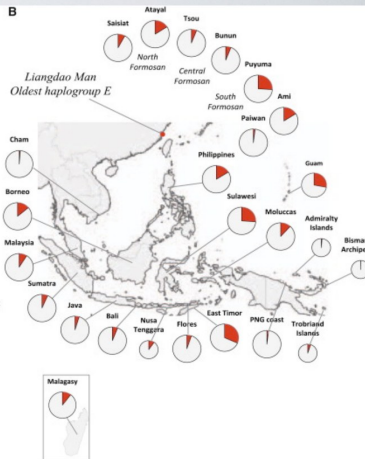
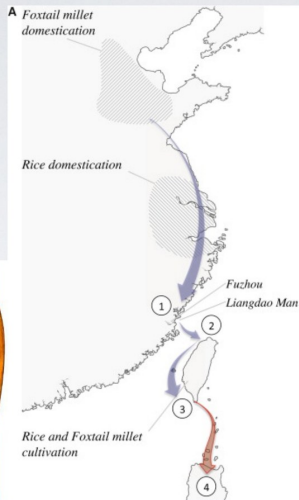
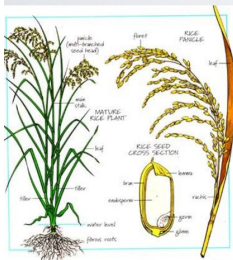
Rice-based Dravidian & Maharati
State-formation

Reconstruction of Austronesian expansion



Bellwood and Dizon 2008

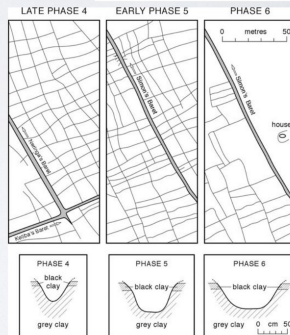
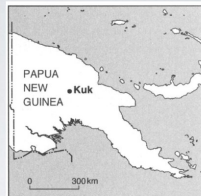
Millets



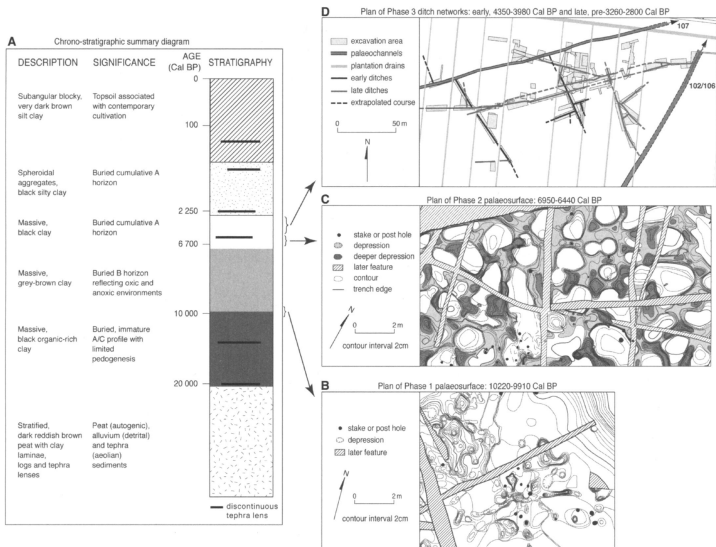
Suggested Migration Route for Early Austronesians Into and Out of Taiwan and the Worldwide Distribution of Haplogroup E1 (A) Geographic regions in China of foxtail millet domestication (source: Ko et al. 2014)

Taro domestication

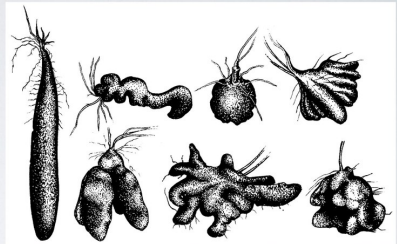
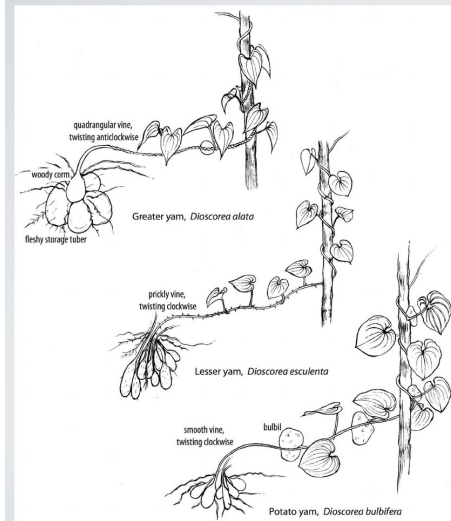
Multidisciplinary investigations at Kuk Swamp in the Highlands of Papua New Guinea show that agriculture arose independently in New Guinea by at least 6950 to 6440 calibrated years before the present (cal yr B.P.). Plant exploitation and some cultivation occurred on the wetland margin at 10,220 to 9910 cal yr B.P. (phase 1), mounding cultivation began by 6950 to 6440 cal yr B.P. (phase 2), and ditched cultivation began by 4350 to 3980 cal yr B.P. (phase 3). Clearance of lower montane rainforests began in the early Holocene, with modification to grassland at 6950 to 6440 cal yr B.P. Taro (*Colocasia esculenta*) was utilized in the early Holocene, and bananas (*Musa* spp.) were intensively cultivated by at least 6950 to 6440 cal yr B.P.



Taro domestication



New Guinean domestications: tubers

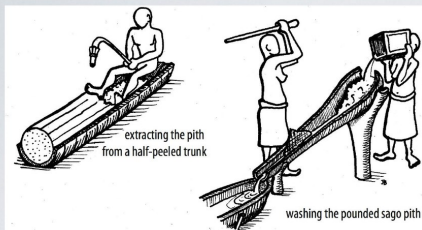


Yams (*Dioscorea alata*)



Taro (*Araceae*) and *Amorphophallus*

New Guinean domestications: sago



New Guinean domestications: banana



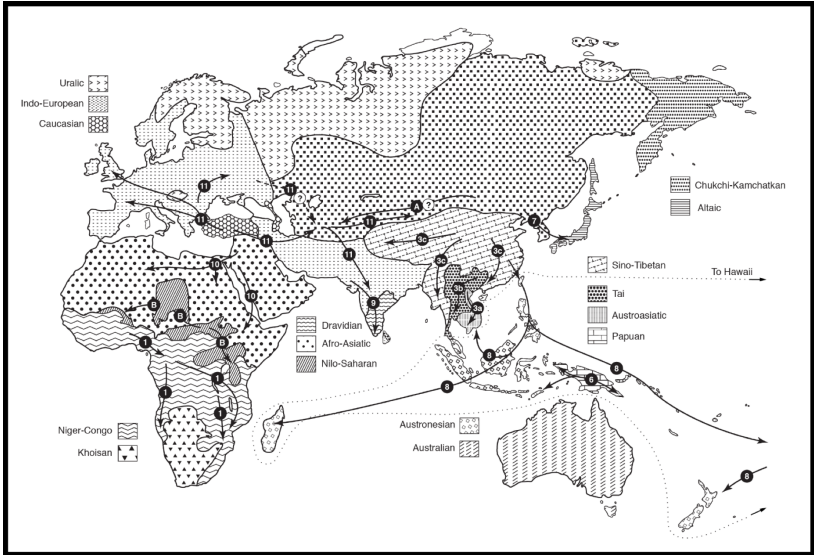
Over 100 new accessions of wild and cultivated bananas were obtained from a wide geographic region including West New Britain, East New Britain, New Ireland, Western Highlands, East Sepik, Madang and Milne Bay



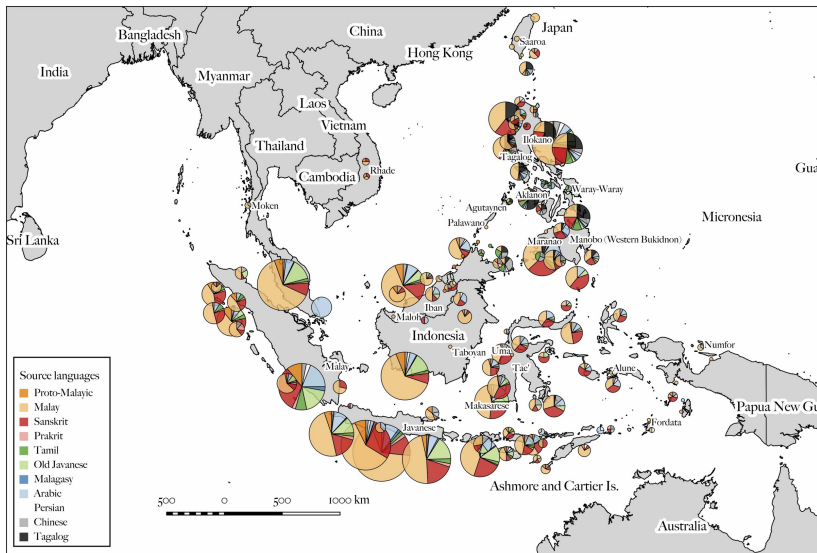
New Guinean domestications: sugar cane



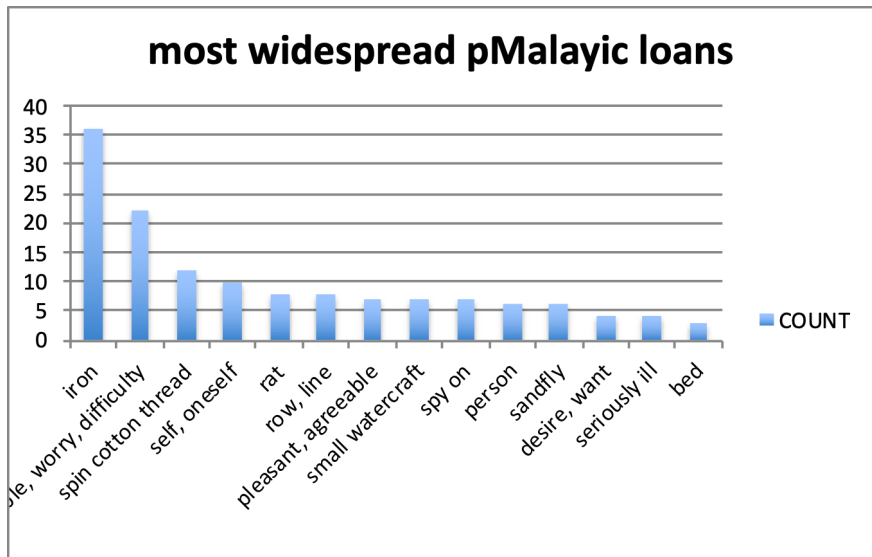
Cultural crops and language family expansions



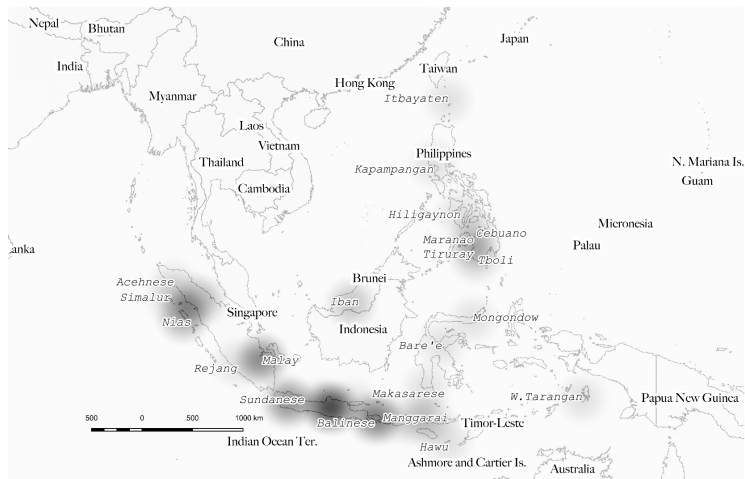
Lexical borrowing in Austronesian



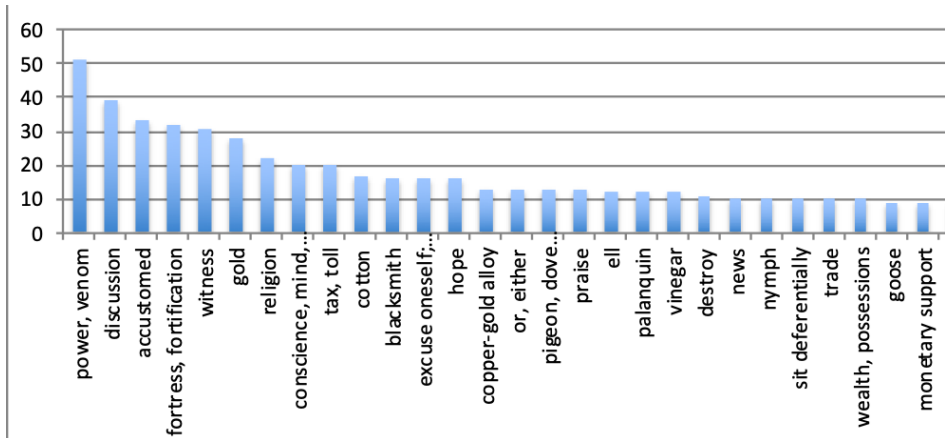
Malayic loanwords



Indic loanwords



Most common Sanskrit loans in languages of SE Asia



Indic loanwords — the 28 most widespread; the tail of another 29 is omitted

		śivō rakṣatu gīrvāṇabhāṣārasāśvādatatparāṇ	
Indian Subcontinent	North	Purvinagari	शिवो रक्षतु गीर्वानभाषारसाश्वदत्तपरान्
		Devanagari	शिवो रक्षतु गीर्वानभाषारसाश्वदत्तपरान्
		Tibetan	ཤི་བོ་རལ་ལུ་གྲི་རལ་མཁའ་ལྷ་སྒྲི་རལ་སྒྲི་དྲ་པ་རྒྱ་ནག་
		Gurumukhi	ਸਿਵੋ ਰਖਤੁ ਗੀਰ੍ਵਾਣਭਾਸਾਸ਼ਵਦਤ੍ਤਪਰਾਨ੍
		Gujanagari	શિવો રક્ષતુ ગીર્વાણભાષારસાશ્વદત્તપરાન્
		Odia	ଶିବୋ ରକ୍ଷତୁ ଗୀର୍ବାଣଭାଷାରସାଶ୍ବଦତ୍ତପରାନ୍
		Kannada	ಶಿವೋ ರಕ್ಷತು ಗೀರ್ವಾಣಭಾಷಾರಸಾಶ್ವದತ್ತಪರಾನ್
		Tamil	ஸிவோ ரக்ஷதது கீர்வாணபாஷாரஸாஸ்வாததத்பராந்
		Telugu	శివో రక్షతు గీర్వాణభాషారసాశ్వాదత్తపరాన్
		Malayalam	ശിവോ രക്ഷതതു ഗീര്വാണഭാഷാരസാശ്വാദതത്പരാന്
		Sinhala	ශිවෝ රක්ෂතු ගීර්වාණභාෂාරසාශ්වාදතත්පරාන්
		Khmer	សិវ រក្សតុ គីរវាណាសាសាស្វាទត្តបរាណី
	Mainland	Thai	ศิว รักษตุ กีร์วานาษารสาสวาทตตปราชัน
		Burmese	ရှိဝေါ ရက္ခတု ကီရ္လီကာဟရသ္မာသ္မာသ္မာသ္မာသ္မာ
		Lao	ຊີວ ຮັກສະຕຸ ຄີວານາຮາສາສະສາສາວາທະຕະປຣາຣາ
Southeast Asia		Sundanese	ꦱꦶꦮꦺꦴꦫꦏꦱꦠꦸꦒꦶꦫꦠꦤ꧀ꦨꦧꦱꦫꦱꦫꦱꦠꦸꦫꦤ꧀
		Lontara	ꦱꦶꦮꦺꦴꦫꦏꦱꦠꦸꦒꦶꦫꦠꦤ꧀ꦨꦧꦱꦫꦱꦫꦱꦠꦸꦫꦤ꧀
		Balinese	ꦱꦶꦮꦺꦴꦫꦏꦱꦠꦸꦒꦶꦫꦠꦤ꧀ꦨꦧꦱꦫꦱꦫꦱꦠꦸꦫꦤ꧀
		Batak	ꦱꦶꦮꦺꦴꦫꦏꦱꦠꦸꦒꦶꦫꦠꦤ꧀ꦨꦧꦱꦫꦱꦫꦱꦠꦸꦫꦤ꧀
		Javanese	ꦱꦶꦮꦺꦴꦫꦏꦱꦠꦸꦒꦶꦫꦠꦤ꧀ꦨꦧꦱꦫꦱꦫꦱꦠꦸꦫꦤ꧀

May Siva bless those who take delight in the language of the gods

Grantha and Pallava scripts

Phoenician	Aramaic	Value	Brahmi	Value
𐤀	𐤁	*	𑀀	a
𐤂	𐤃	b [b]	𑀁	ba
𐤄	𐤅	g [g]	𑀂	ga
𐤆	𐤇	d [d]	𑀃	dha
𐤈	𐤉	h [h], M.L.	𑀄	ha
𐤊	𐤋	w [w], M.L.	𑀅	va
𐤌	𐤍	z [z]	𑀆	ja
𐤏	𐤐	h [h]	𑀇	gha
𐤑	𐤒	t [t]	𑀈	tha
𐤔	𐤕	y [j], M.L.	𑀉	ya
𐤖	𐤗	k [k]	𑀊	ka
𐤙	𐤚	l [l]	𑀋	la
𐤛	𐤜	m [m]	𑀌	ma
𐤞	𐤟	n [n]	𑀍	na
𐤡	𐤢	s [s]	𑀎	sa
𐤤	𐤥	' [ʔ], M.L.	𑀏	e
𐤧	𐤨	p [p]	𑀐	pa
𐤩	𐤪	ś [sʰ]	𑀑	ca
𐤬	𐤭	q [q]	𑀒	kha
𐤮	𐤯	r [r]	𑀓	ra
𐤱	𐤲	ṣ [ʃ]	𑀔	śa
𐤴	𐤵	t [t]	𑀕	ta

Indian scripts are
derived from Greco-
Phoenitian alphabeth

ீ ு ூ ௃ ௄
 k kh g gh ṇ
 ௅ ெ ே ை ௉
 c ch j jh ṇ
 ொ ோ ௌ ் ௎
 t th ḍ dh ṇ
 ௐ ௑ ௒ ௓ ௔
 t th d dh n
 ௖ ௗ ௘ ௙ ௚
 p ph b bh m
 ௜ ௝ ௞ ௟ ௠
 y r l v ṛ
 ௡ ௢ ௣ ௤
 ś ṣ s h

௥ ௦ ௧ ௨ ௩
 a ā i ī u ū
 ௫ ௬ ௭ ௮
 r ṛ ḷ ḹ
 ௰ ௱ ௲ ௳
 e ai o au
 ௴ ௵
 m ḥ

PALLAVA
SCRIPT

Austronesian scripts derived from Indian

Kawi
(700-1500 AD)

Specimen of an Ancient Javanese Inscription

Alphabets not arranged according to the Demanagri classification.

MODERN JAVANESE ALPHABET.

Open Consonants, which the Vowels a or o are always understood to follow.

ha no cho ro ko do la so wo lo po de jo vo nyo mo go bo to ngo
 𑀧 𑀢 𑀣 𑀤 𑀥 𑀦 𑀧 𑀨 𑀩 𑀪 𑀫 𑀬 𑀭 𑀮 𑀯 𑀰 𑀱 𑀲 𑀳 𑀴 𑀵 𑀶 𑀷 𑀸 𑀹 𑀺 𑀻 𑀼 𑀽 𑀾 𑀿

Consonants following Consonants, without a Vowel intervening.

ha no cho ko do to so w lo po do jo nyo mo bo to
 𑀧 𑀢 𑀣 𑀥 𑀦 𑀨 𑀩 𑀫 𑀬 𑀭 𑀮 𑀯 𑀱 𑀲 𑀳 𑀵 𑀶 𑀷 𑀹 𑀺 𑀻 𑀼 𑀾 𑀿

Contractions of Consonants.

h no r modif y ng
 𑀧 𑀢 𑀣 𑀥 𑀦 𑀨 𑀩 𑀫 𑀬 𑀭 𑀮 𑀯 𑀱 𑀲 𑀳 𑀵 𑀶 𑀷 𑀹 𑀺 𑀻 𑀼 𑀾 𑀿

*marks the termination
of a word in a
consonant*

Great Letters used on occasions of Ceremony

ha no ro so bo to
 𑀧 𑀢 𑀣 𑀥 𑀦 𑀨 𑀩 𑀫 𑀬 𑀭 𑀮 𑀯 𑀱 𑀲 𑀳 𑀵 𑀶 𑀷 𑀹 𑀺 𑀻 𑀼 𑀾 𑀿

Vowels and orthographical marks

𑀧 𑀢 𑀣 𑀥 𑀦 𑀨 𑀩 𑀫 𑀬 𑀭 𑀮 𑀯 𑀱 𑀲 𑀳 𑀵 𑀶 𑀷 𑀹 𑀺 𑀻 𑀼 𑀾 𑀿

Beginning of a new passage.

Beginning of a stanza.

Period.

Javanese
(still in use)

𑀧 𑀢 𑀣 𑀥 𑀦
 Hā Nā Cā Rā Kā

𑀧 𑀢 𑀣 𑀥 𑀦
 Dā Tā Sā Wā Lā

𑀧 𑀢 𑀣 𑀥 𑀦
 Mā Gā Bā Ngā

𑀧 𑀢 𑀣 𑀥 𑀦
 Pā Jā Yā Nyā

Balinese
(still in use)

Cham
(still used)

Consonants

𑀧 𑀢 𑀣 𑀥 𑀦 𑀨 𑀩 𑀫 𑀬 𑀭 𑀮 𑀯 𑀱 𑀲 𑀳 𑀵 𑀶 𑀷 𑀹 𑀺 𑀻 𑀼 𑀾 𑀿
 ka kha ga gha ngue nga cha chha ja jha rhue nha nhā
 ta tha da dha nue na dda pa ppa pha ba bha mue ma
 tba ya ra la va ssa sa ya

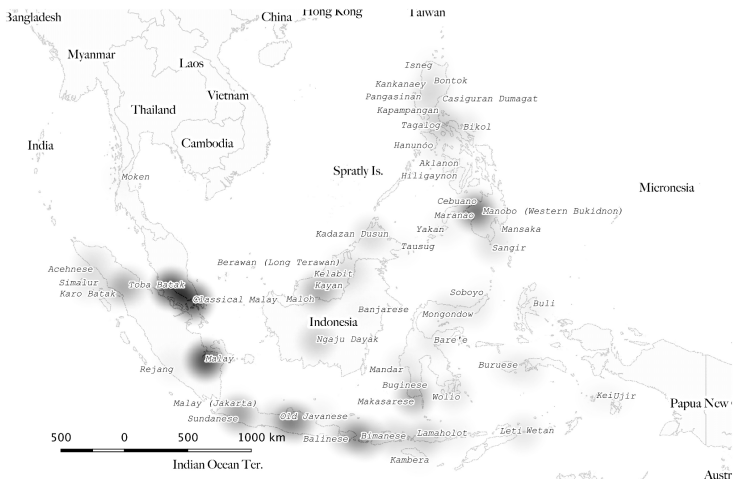
Vowels

𑀧 𑀢 𑀣 𑀥 𑀦 𑀨 𑀩 𑀫 𑀬 𑀭 𑀮 𑀯 𑀱 𑀲 𑀳 𑀵 𑀶 𑀷 𑀹 𑀺 𑀻 𑀼 𑀾 𑀿
 a i u e ai o a i li ei u uu oeu oe ooe e

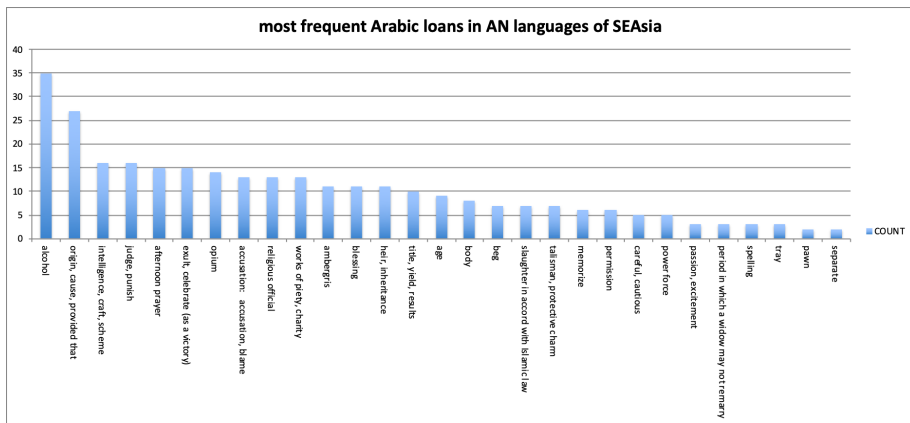
Vowel diacritics

𑀧 𑀢 𑀣 𑀥 𑀦 𑀨 𑀩 𑀫 𑀬 𑀭 𑀮 𑀯 𑀱 𑀲 𑀳 𑀵 𑀶 𑀷 𑀹 𑀺 𑀻 𑀼 𑀾 𑀿
 ee o oo ai au ue uue

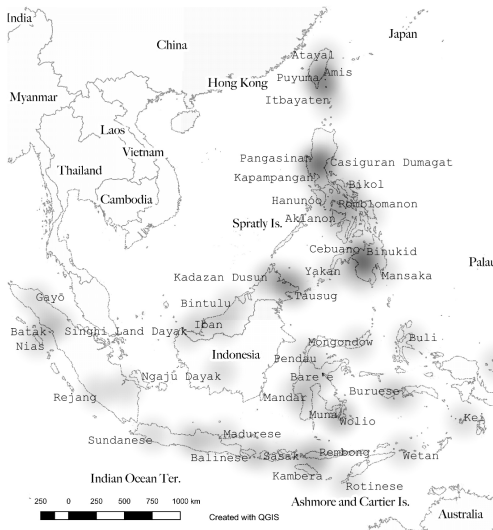
Arabic loanwords



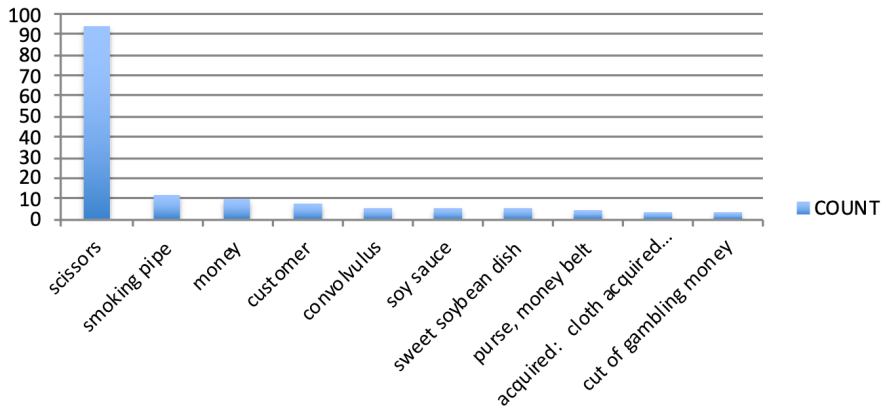
Arabic loanwords



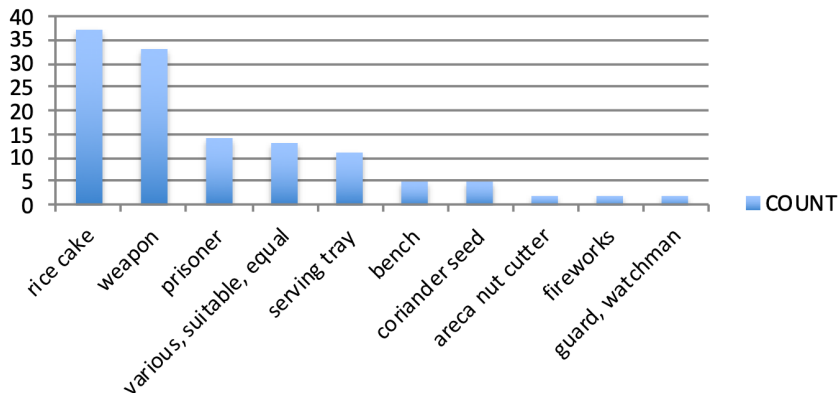
Chinese loanwords



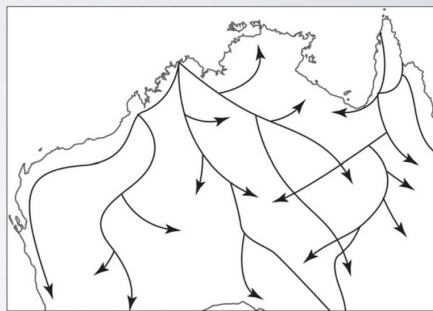
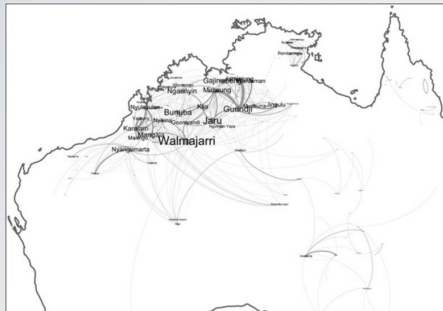
Most widespread Chinese loans



Most common Tamil loans in languages of SEAsia



Wanderwörter in Australian languages



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(the source of the rice maps and phylogenies above)

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- The figures are his, or are reproduced in his slides from the sources named on each slide and listed at the end.
- Rebuilt here in the format of the rest of the course so that it can be maintained and revised alongside the other weeks. Any errors introduced in the rebuilding are mine.
- The same ground is covered at chapter length, with references, in Coupe & Kratochvíl (2020), *Asia before English* — the reading for this week.
- Thanks to František for making the material available.